

2FA RESCUE & RECOVERY CHECKLIST

Use this checklist with the Season 1, Part 2 article to harden your two-factor authentication (2FA) and make sure you can get back into critical accounts if you lose a phone, authenticator app, or hardware key.



1. PREPARE YOUR IDENTITY AND CONTACT DETAILS

- ☐ Primary email account is secured with strong password and 2FA.
- ☐ Recovery email is set and belongs to you (not a work or school address that could disappear).
- ☐ Recovery phone number is current and accessible to you.
- ☐ You have verified that you can receive SMS or calls to the recovery phone, if used.

2. INVENTORY YOUR CRITICAL ACCOUNTS

- ☐ You have a list of your top critical accounts (email, password manager, banking, cloud storage, social media, key work apps).
- ☐ Each account is marked with its priority (High/Medium/Low) based on impact if you get locked out.
- ☐ You know which accounts depend on others (for example, which accounts use your main email for password resets).
- ☐ All critical accounts have 2FA enabled where available.

3. LOCK DOWN AUTHENTICATOR APPS AND DEVICES

- ☐ Your primary authenticator app (or phone) has a screen lock enabled (PIN, password, or biometrics).
- ☐ The device running your authenticator app is encrypted (e.g., BitLocker, FileVault, or built-in phone encryption).
- ☐ You are signed out of authenticator apps on devices you no longer use.
- ☐ You know how to move or export your authenticator tokens when replacing a phone.

4. CAPTURE AND STORE BACKUP CODES AND RECOVERY OPTIONS

- ☐ For each supported account, backup codes have been generated once 2FA was turned on.
- ☐ Backup codes are stored in an encrypted password manager, secure file, or printed and stored in a safe location.

- ☐ You have at least one backup method per critical account (backup codes, second device, or hardware key).
- ☐ Recovery questions, if still used, are not easily guessable from your public information.

5. HARDWARE SECURITY KEYS (IF USED)

- ☐ Primary hardware key is registered with critical accounts that support it.
- ☐ At least one backup hardware key is registered for those accounts where possible.
- ☐ You have labeled keys so you can tell primary from backup without exposing secrets.
- ☐ Hardware keys are stored in known, consistent locations (for example, one on keychain, one in a safe).

6. TEST YOUR RECOVERY PATHS

- ☐ You have tested signing in to at least one critical account using backup codes.
- ☐ You have practiced using a backup device or hardware key for at least one account.
- ☐ You confirmed that recovery emails or SMS messages actually arrive as expected.
- ☐ You understand the account recovery process for your main email and password manager.

7. CREATE AN EMERGENCY PLAN

- ☐ You have a simple written plan for what to do if you lose your phone or authenticator device.
- ☐ You know which account to recover first (usually your main email and password manager).
- ☐ You have decided whether any trusted person should know how to access your recovery information in an emergency.
- ☐ You keep this checklist and your 2FA Recovery Kit workbook together in a secure location.

8. MAINTENANCE AND REVIEW

- ☐ You have a calendar reminder to review 2FA and recovery information at least once per year.
- ☐ Old or unused devices and tokens are removed from your accounts.
- ☐ Any changes to phone numbers, emails, or hardware keys are updated in your 2FA Recovery Kit workbook.
- ☐ You periodically export or refresh backup codes when major changes are made to accounts.